model of Agni was tested in the DLR wind tunnel. An immediate denial came from the DLR, who in turn speculated that France had supplied the Agni guidance electronics. American Senator Jeff Bingaman even went to the extent of suggesting that I picked up everything needed for Agni during my four-month stay at Wal op's Island in 1962. The fact that I was in Wal op's Island more than 25 years ago and at that time the technology used in Agni did not exist even in the United States was not mentioned.

In today's world, technological backwardness leads to subjugation. Can we al ow our freedom to be compromised on this account? It is our bounden duty to guarantee the security and integrity of our nation against this threat. Should we not uphold the mandate bequeathed to us by our forefathers who fought for the liberation of our country from imperialism? Only when we are technological y self-reliant wil we able to fulfil their dream.

Til the Agni launch, the Indian Armed Forces had been structured for a strictly defensive role to safeguard our nation, to shield our democratic processes from the turbulence in the countries around us and to raise the cost of any external intervention to an unacceptable level for